The Party Never Ends? Evidence of Nationalization in Local Politics*

Christopher Vazquez†

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Abstract

Is American local political behavior becoming nationalized? Nationalization suggests that local political behavior also has partisan elements. However, local government and politics have a lot of nonpartisan elements, and previous research in local political behavior relies on measures of national policy preferences from mass surveys. It is still unknown if there is a relationship between national and local preferences. One potential relationship is that individuals could evaluate local policies in a partisan lens when they only operate in a national context. To test the role of context in local policy preferences, I conducted an original survey that primes respondents with different contexts to influence local policy preferences. Despite the experiment being ineffective, I find through principal component analysis that there are divisions in local policy preferences that align with respondents' partisanship. This finding illustrates that partisanship could also define local policy preferences as it does national preferences.

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†Ph.D. Student, Department of Political Science, *Massachusetts Institute of Technology.* chris_v@mit.edu.

Introduction

Partisanship is one of the main drivers of vote choice in American politics. Over time, partisans are increasingly more likely to vote for candidates of their own party and adopt the policies of co-partisans (Bartels 2000; Lenz 2012; Jacobson 2013; Barber and Pope 2019). Partisan identity helps Americans understand and interpret the political world, having it serve as a shortcut to make political decision-making easier (Lupia 1994). However, the role of partisanship in policy preference formation has recently seen a shift, with some researchers arguing that individuals first have policy preferences and then chose their partisan allegiance afterwards, and the dominant view of partisanship is the result of reverse causation (Fowler 2020; Orr, Fowler, and Huber 2023). This new argument has created a tension where individuals are just behaving according to their partisan identity or if partisan behavior and attitudes originate from underlying policy preferences.

Research on partisanship has also been extended to studies on subnational politics. Studies have suggested that local politics are becoming nationalized, or that local political behavior mirrors national political behavior. Nationalization is suggested to have two distinct facets. First, voters rely on their partisanship to select candidates at the local level. Second, voters are more engaged with national politics at the exclusion of local politics (Hopkins 2018). While researchers have been able to find partisan elements at the local level (Warshaw 2019), others have argued that it is still too early to attribute partisanship to local political behavior.

Local government and politics are primarily focuses on services and economic development, which involves extremely technical policies that typically aren't divided by partisanship (Oliver, Ha, and Callen 2012; Peterson 1981). Additionally, most city elections are nonpartisan, so voters don't have the option to rely on partisanship while voting. Most importantly, most studies on nationalization rely on measures of policy preferences on national policies (Anzia 2021). This is problematic because there is currently not enough work done to examine the relationship between national policy preferences and local policy preferences.

The gap in the understanding of local political behavior ultimately goes back to the tension in policy preference formation introduced by Fowler (2020). The two sides of the argument are that individuals behave as partisans and make their decisions based on their party ID or that individuals have policy preferences that ultimately dictate their behavior. In local politics, individuals can base their decisions off their national preferences (partisanship) or off any local policy preference that they may have. To gain a deeper understanding of the underlying mechanism driving local political behavior, we would need to conduct more research on local policy preferences.

Recently, others have been able to conduct surveys and experiments on local policy preferences and have made interesting findings. One finding that is particularly important for the nationalization argument comes from Marble & Nall's 2020 study on housing preferences. They found that Democrats are more likely to support federal government involvement in housing development. Interestingly, they also discovered that support from Democrats goes away when the focus shifts to local policies, as Democrats become self-interested rather than ideological. I believe this finding offers incredible insight on whether partisanship or self-interest can drive local policy preference.

In this paper, I explore whether partisanship or self-interest influences support for various local policies. Drawing from Marble & Nall's (2020) study, I propose that the context in which individuals perceive policies shapes their thinking. A national context influences people to focus on national actors and policies, while a local context leads individuals to consider local policies and prioritize their own interests. In other words, a national context may influence individuals to be partisans while a local context may influence individuals to be self-interested when considering policies enacted by local governments.

To study the influence of context in local policy preference formation, I conducted an original survey of a nationally representative sample with over 1,400 respondents. This survey was conducted over the online survey platform Cint (formerly known as Lucid) in the spring of 2025. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of two treatments where

they were exposed to a national context prompt or a local context prompt. Ultimately, the experimental primes had no effect on policy preferences, but I did find pertinent relationships in a descriptive analysis.

Using principal component analysis, I found that local policies are viewed on two different dimensions: expansion of local government, and a pro-policing/pro-market dimension. Support for expanding local governments and services comes from Democrats and support for policing/market solutions comes from Republicans. Along an issue-based analysis, I further confirm that Democrats prefer expansion of city services and Republicans are very pro-police. Using a two-step post-Lasso model, I ultimately find that partisanship is what drives preferences on local policies, even when accounting for important background variables such as homeownership status and parenthood.

This project contributes to the nationalization argument by providing additional evidence of partisan behavior in local politics. Even though local governments are focused on providing services in a nonpartisan fashion, individuals could still ultimately view the actions of local governments in a partisan lens. The same ideologies that influence national preferences can still be used to evaluate local policies, making it easier for individuals to simplify local politics and form preferences.

This project also addresses the larger question on whether individuals are partisans first or have policy preferences that drive their behaviors. If individuals were truly self-interested, they would make decisions on local policies based on their background, regardless of their partisan identity as suggested by the NIMBYism literature. However, this paper illustrates that while certain background traits are still important for preference formation, partisanship still plays a huge role in influencing individual local policy preferences. There is a difference between how Democrats and Republicans view their local governments and the services they provide.

Partisanship in American Politics

Partisanship is one of the primary influences in American political decision-making. Traditionally, it was believed that voters were primarily influenced by their own policy preferences and voted according to their own self-interest. Over the past decades, it has been suggested that Americans aren't politically sophisticated and rely on their partisan identity for most political decisions. Because partisanship attachments are socialized early and remain remarkable stable, they serve as an anchor through with people interpret subsequent information (Campbell and Center 1980; Converse 1964; Achen and Bartels 2017). Over time, partisan behavior has only continued to grow, as evident in voters' increasing likelihood to vote for candidates of their own party as well as adopt the policy preferences of said candidates (Bartels 2000; Lenz 2012; Jacobson 2013; Barber and Pope 2019). Most notably, some are starting to argue that partisanship has become a hyper-identity to many Americans. Cross-cutting social cleavages, which used to counter each other, are now starting to be swallowed by partisan identity. Religious and racial identities are starting to become linked together and groups are "sorting" themselves between different parties (Mason 2018). Partisanship is an important aspect of many American's identities, and that has become evident in voting behavior across the United States.

Partisanship has become an important part of American politics for a myriad of factors, one being that it makes politics easier for the average citizen by serving as a heuristic. Partisanship has long functioned as a cognitive shortcut, allowing even minimally informed citizens to take positions that could roughly match political sophisticates (Downs 1957; Lupia 1994). What has changed is not the heuristic role itself but the extent to which citizens must rely on it in today's information environment, which is incredibly saturated with news on national politics. Partisanship serves as one of many shortcuts for voters because they can quickly gather information through easily accessible channels such as the internet and social media. Most importantly, voters can make quick decisions at the polls by easily accessing candidates' partisanship and selecting co-partisans. Americans can adopt

the policy preferences of co-partisans without the costs of individual information gathering and the complex mental process to form individual preferences.

Despite the overwhelming evidence that partisanship drives vote choice, the focus of recent research has turned towards partisanship's influence on policy preferences. The main argument from Achen & Bartels (2016) is that social identity is an important driver of political behavior. They reflect on a folk theory of democracy which suggests that voters have real policy preferences and elect candidates based on those preferences and alternatively argue that voting patterns are determined by group loyalties. Echoing what has been argued by Converse, voters lack stable ideologies and rely on judgments based on reflecting on their identity and letting co-partisans dictate what to think about certain issues (Converse 1964; Lenz 2012). Partisanship can be considered a group-based social identity meaning that individuals' perceptions of self involve membership of a larger group unit. The perception of group membership leads to the attributes and behaviors of individuals to assimilate to the group as a whole (Brewer 2001). Partisanship is a strong group identity, similar to religious or ethnic identities, that is deeply ingrained and enduring over time. This identity's strength is seen through partisans being more engaged in politics and with partisan attachment being unresponsive to changes in the environment (Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2004). Partisan identity helps individuals make sense of the political world, and voters can rely on it as an easy shortcut to find "people who are like them" that they can easily choose at the voting booth.

The alternative argument against Achen and Bartels suggests that partisanship might not be as influential as previously portrayed. The relationship between vote choice and partisan identity may be evidence of a reverse causation, meaning that people have certain policy preferences that align with a certain party, and then choose to vote for that party. Recent research has pushed against "partisan intoxication" by showing that individuals behave differently when they start to receive more information about candidate policy positions (Fowler 2020). Most notably, it has been shown that partisans care much more about

policy agreement than party loyalty when the two come into conflict. Individuals prefer co-partisans that agree with them over party-loyal co-partisans. The connection between partisanship and policy preferences might be that people tend to believe that co-partisans share similar preferences and are willing to update their support for candidates with new information (Orr, Fowler, and Huber 2023). This new perspective of partisanship still leaves room for individuals to adopt policy preferences of elites and to use partisanship as a shortcut for decision-making (Rogers 2020). However, the tension in the literature on partisanship comes from whether individuals are just behaving according to their partisan identity or if partisan behavior and attitudes originate from underlying policy preferences. In the next section, I ask whether partisanship extends to evaluations of local policy, an area where party cues are considered muted. Valuable insight on the origins of mass policy preferences can be gained by analyzing how partisanship competes with other identities when individuals consider local policy proposals.

Nationalization of American Political Behavior

Recently, research has started to extend theories of partisan behavior across the different levels of government and politics in the American federal system. Scholars are arguing that political behavior has become nationalized, or uniform across the country. In *The Increasingly United States*, Daniel Hopkins defines the nationalization of politics using two facets, the first being that voters use the same criteria to select candidates across the federal system. Hopkins argues that voters elect candidates by party ID in state and local elections in addition to national elections. By analyzing gubernatorial election results, Hopkins finds that there is a pattern of increasing correlation between presidential and gubernatorial election results and concludes that vote-decisions are being decided by partisanship. Hopkins' second facet to nationalization is that voters are increasingly engaged with national politics at the exclusion of state and local politics. Hopkins found that voter knowledge of subnational politics is on a decreasing trend as well as turnout in subnational elections. Meanwhile,

campaign contributions that cross state lines has increased from 31.4% to 67.8% from 1990 to 2012, and these contributions have been focused on national offices rather than state/local offices (Hopkins 2018). Overall, Hopkins' argument is that behavior at the subnational level is starting to mirror national political behavior, with individuals continuously relying on their partisan identity in elections across the levels of government and focusing their attention to national politics rather than the politics in their own neighborhoods.

In the past few decades, scholars have been investigating the role of partisanship and ideology at the municipal level and have found some evidence that supports Hopkins' claims of nationalization. There is evidence of partisanship playing an important role in mayoral elections and that there is a relationship between the party/ideology of voters and the mayors they vote for (Z. Hajnal and Trounstine 2014; Boudreau, Elmendorf, and MacKenzie 2015; Sances 2018). Additionally, using mass ideology data from large national surveys, research has found that there is a strong association in cities that are liberal (conservative) being more likely to elect Democrats (Republicans) for mayoral and county elections (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2013; De Benedictis-Kessner and Warshaw 2016; De Benedictis-Kessner and Warshaw 2020). These findings suggest that partisan behavior could be happening at the local level just as it does in the national level, which could imply that political behavior is becoming nationalized.

There is also additional evidence to support Hopkins' second facet to nationalization. First, voter turnout for local elections is extremely low compared to national elections, where less than 40% of voters participate in mayoral and city council elections (Z. L. Hajnal 2009). According to Hopkins (2018), turnout for local elections is continuing to fall, a trend that's linked to a growing attention to national politics. Outside of voting, research on participation in local politics is sparse, making it hard to make further conclusions on the presence of nationalization in local politics. However, recent studies have shown evidence of shifting media markets, with news sources becoming more focused on national politics rather than local politics (Martin and McCrain 2019). While further research should be done on

local participation, the current evidence suggests that engagement in local politics is low and could be limited by an increasing shift in attention to national politics.

The Limited Role of Parties in Local Politics

To date we still lack systematic evidence that nationalization penetrates local politics; the handful of studies that do exist have important limitations to consider. Municipal governments are primarily concerned with economic development, management of land, and providing services such as sewage, waste management, utilities, street repair, parks, and police/fire protection (Oliver, Ha, and Callen 2012). Cities compete for tax-generating businesses and land value to attract high-skilled labor and improve their economic growth prospects. This competition drives them to constantly enhance their services and opportunities, ultimately boosting their revenue sources (Peterson 1981). While the types of services are broadly similar, the scale, financing, and quality vary immensely across cities. But given the function of cities, it can be easy to agree that "there is no Republican way to pave a street and no Democratic way to lay a sewer" (Adrian 1952) and that perhaps nationalization doesn't apply to local politics. A crucial point that Sarah Anzia (Anzia 2021) raises is that while the recent evidence arguing that partisan behavior occurs at the local level is strong, it has not paid sufficient attention to the policy particulars of local government. Most studies have primarily focused on ideological scales and public opinion data from national surveys such as the CCES and the ANES (Tausanovitch and Warshaw 2014; Hopkins 2018). While using ideology measures is intuitive, there is not enough evidence to conclude that these measures correlate with the formation of preferences on particular local policies. Additionally, the questions from the CCES and ANES are primarily about national policy issues, meaning that previous research has just been measuring local-level preferences on national politics.

Another key point is that city electoral institutions are different than national elections. First, approximately 75% of local elections are formally nonpartisan (Wood 2002). Candidates that run for many local offices do not run with a party, meaning that voters do not

have the partisan heuristic to rely on for their decision-making. Second, many local elections are not concurrent with national elections and occur during odd numbered years in months other than November such as April or May. Not only do off-cycle elections result in lower turnout (Anzia 2013; Z. L. Hajnal 2009; Kogan, Lavertu, and Peskowitz 2018), but they possibly could be associated with an attempt at separation from national politics.

Research on local mass behavior, such as the formation of local policy preferences, remains surprising scarce. In a conjoint survey experiment, Jensen et al. did not find a large difference in support for local development policies between Democrats and Republicans. However, they did find some evidence for polarization in education and labor issues, which they suggest could be due to the strength of national partisan cues in these areas. For other policies, any partisan difference they observe in their strategies were mainly a function of differences in sex, race, and homeownership (Jensen et al. 2021). Jensen et al. point out the important consideration that other identities can cross pressure and limit the influence of partisanship in local politics. For example, it has been shown that homeownership status can be a primary predictor of housing policy preferences. A survey experiment revealed that while liberals are more inclined to support federal government involvement in housing policy, they are less likely to support local housing development if they are homeowners (Marble and Nall 2021). Additionally, there was no difference in participation rates by Democrats and Republicans in a study done on participation in planning and zoning board meetings (Einstein, Palmer, and Glick 2019). These preliminary findings on local political behavior indicate that partisanship may not be as significant as nationalization scholars propose.

Party or Policy?

The tension that comes from the nationalization literature ultimately ties back to the tension that comes from the debates on partisanship. The first facet of nationalization suggests that voters rely on their partisan identity to select candidates, even at the state and local level. The mechanism that underlies nationalization's first facet lines up well with the view of

partisanship that was argued by Achen & Bartels, where partisanship is a social identity that is the primary driver of vote choice. On the other hand, Anzia's appraisal of studies on partisanship in local politics echoes the concerns brought forth by Fowler's paper on "partisan intoxication" where attention is shifted to individual policy preferences. To clarify, Anzia's 2021 review is not arguing against nationalization, rather, it is suggesting that further research should be done in local politics to see if the dimensions of policy preferences are laid out in a way that mirrors a partisan divide. This would involve a shift towards focusing on local policy preferences in addition to social identity as suggested by Fowler.

Ultimately, the major question is what is the role of partisanship and policy preferences in national politics vs local politics? Studies on nationalization suggest that partisanship remains the primary factor but that is put into question when many elements of local governments and politics lack partisanship altogether. Theoretically, I argue that existing nationalization accounts overlook mechanisms unique to local policy—especially material self-interest and place-based externalities—while empirically I demonstrate that inattention to local preferences can overstate the reach of partisan identity. Most nationalization research implicitly assumes that the strength of the link between partisan identification and national-level attitudes carries over unchanged to local domains. To gain a better understanding of local political behavior, it would be important to understand what preferences people have at the local level while also considering the multi-faceted nature of nationalization.

One important concept to consider when examining the tension between the importance of partisan identity and local policy preference is that local political behavior is context-dependent, or shaped by place-specific conditions and actors. To reiterate, Hopkins' second facet of nationalization is that voters are more engaged with national politics than local. It's also important to note that the research on local political behavior did find partisan differences in education, labor, and housing development preferences. For education and labor, Jensen et al. (2019) was not able to directly test if these issues were polarized due to strong partisan cues (that would be outside the scope of the paper). But for housing,

Marble & Nall (2020) show that partisan differences exist when the policy is nationalized (when individuals were told about the involvement of the federal government), and that those differences go away when the policy is placed in a local context where individuals thought about their own policy preferences.

While recent research shows that there may not be a clear partisan divide, it doesn't deeply investigate whether there are clear differences when individuals are exposed to either a national or local context as potentially suggested by Marble & Nall. When individuals think of "national politics," a whole world of thoughts could flood their minds that involve concepts such as their partisan identity, elections, the sitting president, and more (Zaller 1992). A national context could be what influences individuals to form preferences when they think of certain policies such as housing. However, when individuals view policies in a local context, they may consider their own communities along with their local self-interests, which could result in the formation of different preferences when considering the same policies. In other words, individuals can override their partisan identities to pursue their self-interests when operating in a local context.

In this paper, I test that partisan identity still serves as an important heuristic in local policy preferences unless the policy is framed in a local context. Local context can weaken partisan identity if made salient. Individuals will not use partisanship as a shortcut when a local policy confronts them with personal or neighborhood implications. This leads me to form the following two hypotheses:

> **H1:** While operating in a national context, individual policy preferences will align with PID.

> **H2:** In a local context, individual policy preferences will align with self-interest.

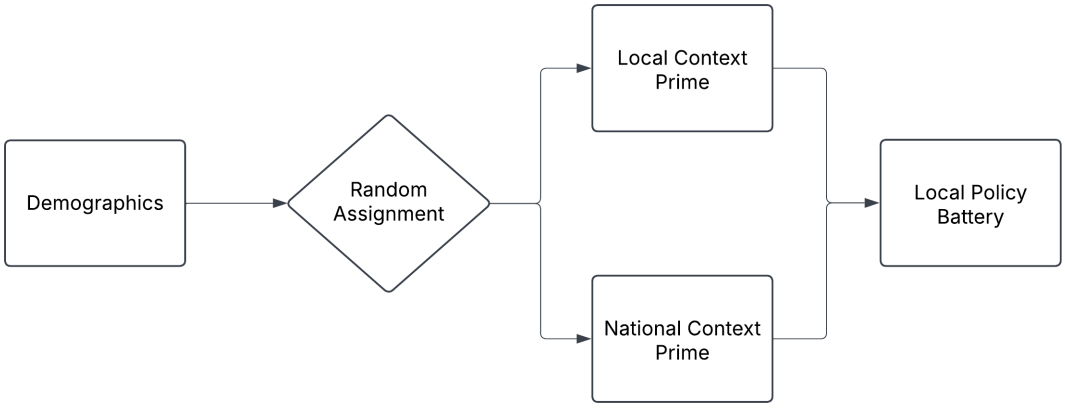
These hypotheses focus on investigating whether partisanship local identity and contexts can trump partisanship in local policy preference formation. We already know that partisanship is crucial in political decision-making, yet we do not know whether it dominates when

individuals form preferences at the local level. Sarah Anzia's (2021) review raises a crucial point that opens the door to several directions of research for local political behavior while also presenting a difficult task to research since there are so many factors at play in local government and politics. Looking at Hopkin's facets of nationalization and the theories of preference formation offered by previous research, this paper aims to investigate the role of partisanship and context in local policy preference formation.

Survey Design

To study the role of context in local policy preference, I conducted an original survey experiment with a nationally representative sample of 1400 respondents recruited through Cint (formerly known as Lucid) in April 2025. After answering several demographic questions, survey respondents were randomly assigned between two treatment groups where they received a National or a Local prime that was intended to promote a mindset, or context, for the rest of the survey. After the prime, respondents were asked to indicate support or opposition to a battery of 18 local policy statements that involved housing, public safety, education, social welfare, infrastructure, and recreation. The framing manipulation is expected to provide evidence of **H1** demonstrating that the correlation between partisan identity and support for local policies will be stronger in the *National* condition. Evidence for **H2** will be shown through a relationship of preferences between other social identities such as homeownership status, parenthood, age, race, education, and income, while partisanship explains less variance.

Figure 1: Survey Flow Diagram



N = 1416. Cint already screens out bots but the survey had its own screening process after respondents indicated consent. The survey also included attention checks after collecting demographics, the treatment, and in the middle of the local policy battery.

The primes for both the National and Local treatment groups consisted of small prompts that were meant to immerse respondents in their assigned context. Each prompt was a short narrative about engaging in national/local elections and mentions campaigning, media coverage, and political conversations that are meant to help respondents imagine typical experiences with politics at either the national or local level. After each prompt, respondents were given a reflection exercise where they were asked to reflect on the most recent national/local election and to write a few words about how they felt about politics at that time. Below are the primes that respondents were exposed to:

> *National Prompt:* Imagine that it is election season again. Every day, TV ads, podcasts, and social-media feeds are filled with updates about politics from Washington D.C. Reporters are tracking the latest bills and debates in Congress, approval ratings and polls, as well as headlines about the President.
>
> Commentators frame these events as pivotal for the country's future and political parties flood the airwaves urging Americans to support their side. Friends, relatives, and co-workers trade messages about politics and discuss which politicians they trust to lead the country.

Local Prompt: Imagine that it is election season again. In neighborhoods across the country, residents see flyers on doorsteps, lawn signs on street corners, and stories in the local paper about the upcoming city elections. Local reporters are tracking city-council debates and updating everyone on the mayor's latest statements.

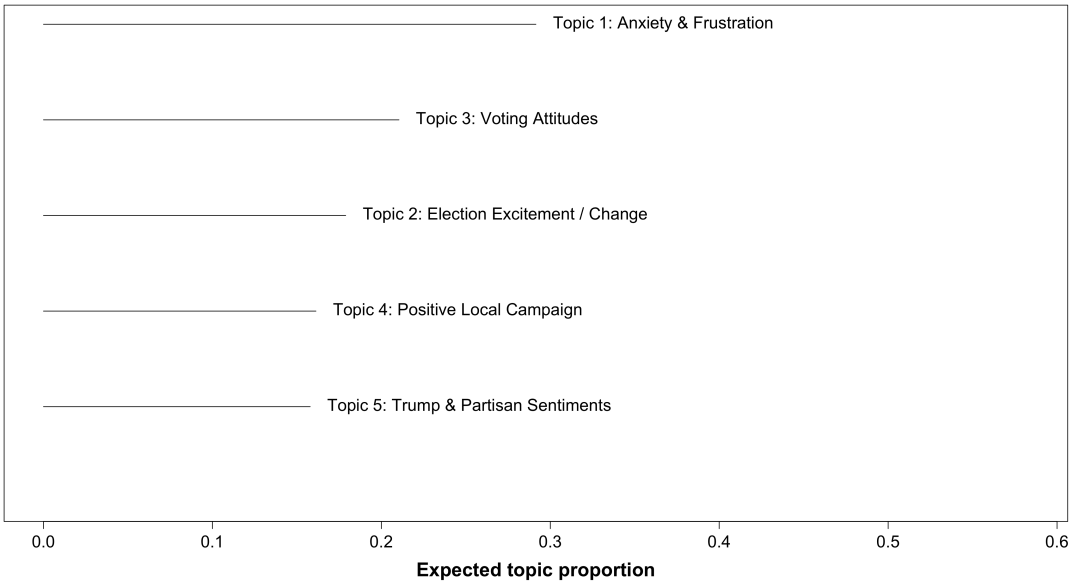
Community forums buzz with conversations about which candidates understand the neighborhood's needs and volunteers knock on doors asking voters to show up on election day. Local newscasters remind residents that these contests can shape their daily quality of life.

After the reflection exercise, respondents were exposed to a series of policies where they were asked to indicate support or opposition. The policies were displayed in 3 separate grids with 6 distinct policy issues that were randomized between respondents. I intentionally chose policies such as housing, education, public safety, and social welfare because they are easily nationalized, and respondents in the national conditions could easily display preferences that map onto their partisan identities. I also included local policies that involve infrastructure and parks since they don't easily map onto national divisions. Preferences towards these policies may show the limits of nationalization and that the theory only applies to certain policy issues.

Response to Primes

To see how respondents reacted the primes, I analyzed the open-ended responses using a Structural Topic Model (STM). STM assumes each open-ended response is a mixture of latent topics and allows for topics to shift with respondent-level covariates while also accounting for topic correlations. The main benefits of STM is that it allows for the estimation of coefficients and standard errors for treatment effects while also discovering the topics themselves, which is useful for quantifying how respondents between the national and local primes used different topics.

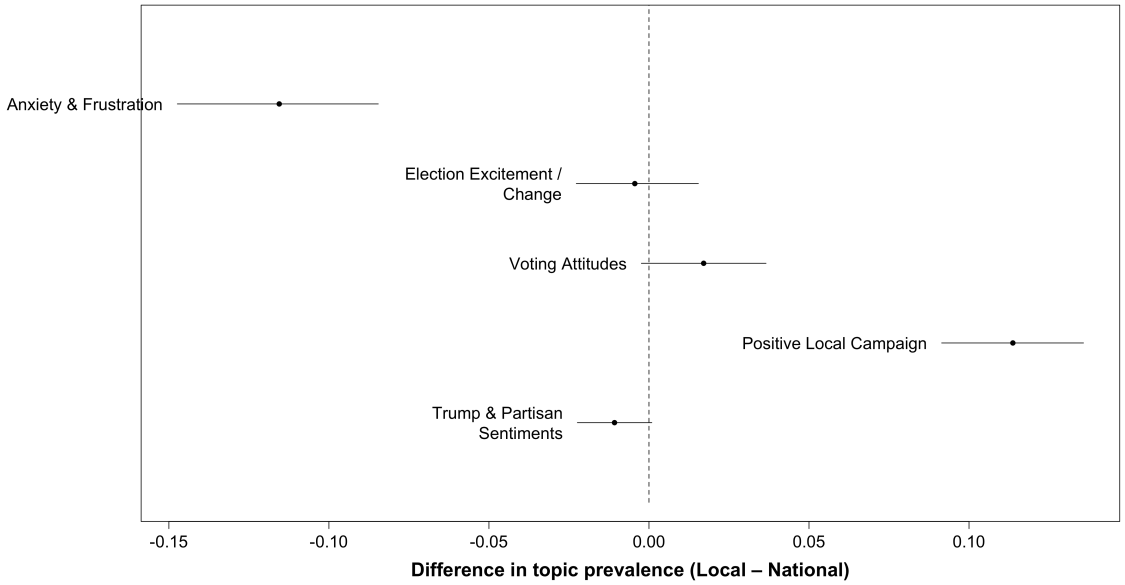
Figure 2: Topic Prevalence



X-Axis measures proportions in tokens.

Figure 2 displays the expected topic proportions for the five topics that I discovered using STM. The topics are: 1) Anxiety & Frustration, 2) Election Excitement/Change, 3) Voting Attitudes, 4) Positive Local Campaign, and 5) Trump & Partisan Sentiments. Figure 2 shows that most respondents responded to the reflection exercise by expressing anxiety & frustration and that this topic accounts for approximately 30% of all tokens. On the other hand, the least mentioned topic by respondents is Trump with partisan sentiments. Overall, the main takeaway from all open-ended responses is that there was a lot of negativity, but there was also a lot of positive sentiments towards local elections.

Figure 3: Treatment Effects on Open-Ended Responses



Values calculated by subtracting prevalence in the national treatment from the local treatment. Topics on the right were more prevalent in the local treatment group than the national group. Topics that cross zero were equally likely to appear in both groups. Topics were interpreted by the author and validated using ChatGPT.

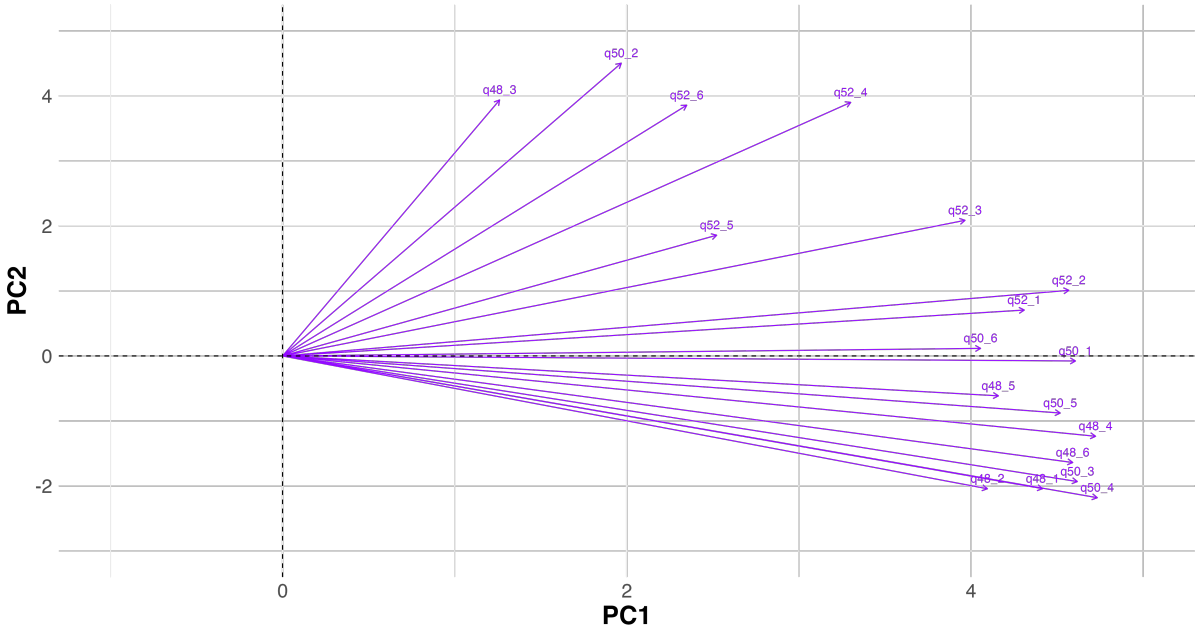
Figure 3 looks closer at the treatment effects and whether there was a difference in topic prevalence between respondents in the *Local* group and the *National* group. First, responses that involved anxiety & frustration were less likely to be given by respondents in the *Local* group than those who were primed with national politics. Second, respondents in the *Local*group were more likely to share positive experiences with their local elections. Finally, the null result for the Trump topic suggests that mentions of Trump remain stable across both primes. Taken together, the results from the STM show that the primes were not extremely effective. Intuitively, respondents were more negative when they had to talk about national elections and more positive when they talked about their local elections. Despite the shift of attention, both treatment groups were equally likely to talk about partisanship and the president. This could be the result of a weaker treatment, respondents not paying enough attention, or both. For a further investigation, I will also examine if local policy

preferences shifted between treatment groups.

Dimensions of Local Policy Preference

The primary analysis that I'll be using for this survey data will be principal component analysis (PCA). With PCA, I'm able to combine the responses from the 18-item local policy battery to just a small set of dimensions that will capture the bulk of variation in responses. PCA will also allow me to calculate scales to measure support for local policies, allowing me to measure the relationship of identities and policy preference. By working with principal components, I'm able to avoid collinearity in downstream analysis and visualize how policies cluster conceptually. These results will allow me to analyze the dimensions of local policy preferences and if they are related to partisanship or other identities.

Figure 4: Biplot of PCA Loadings

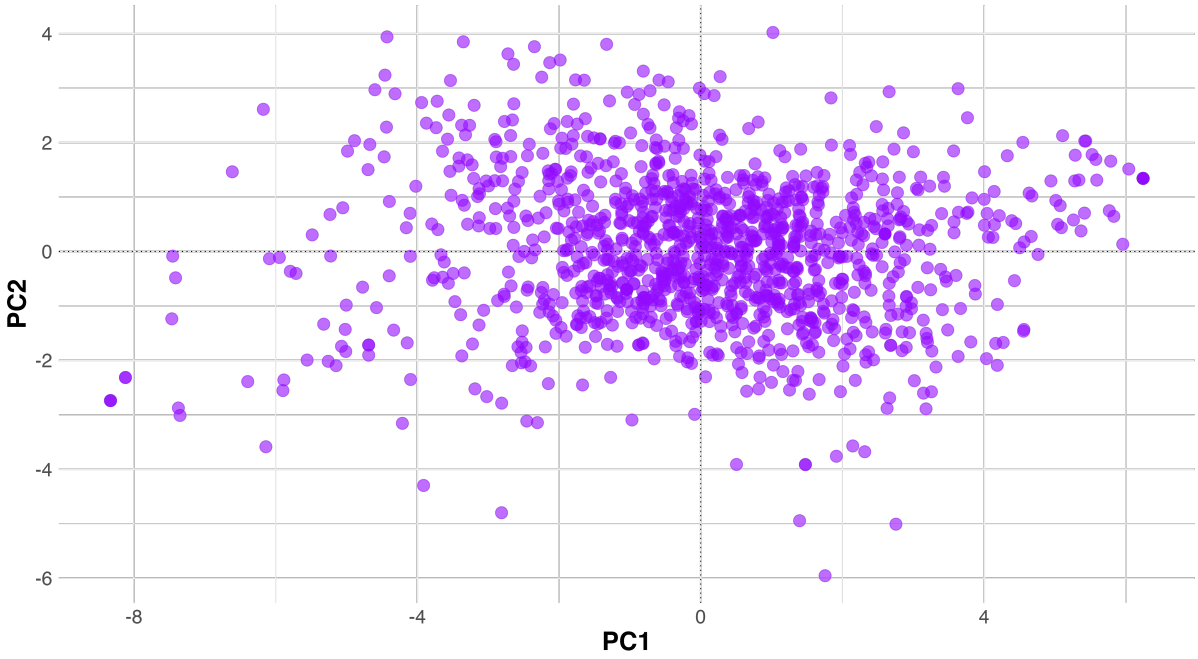


PC1 only has positive values. PC2 has both negative and positive values by negative values only go down to -2. Each line represents the magnitude of loadings for each question.

Figure 4 displays a biplot of each policy item as an arrow in the plane of PC1 and

PC2. All 18 arrows are positive for PC1, which suggests that PC1 can be interpreted as a general support for the expansion of local services/government. Along PC2's axis, the arrow are split between positive and negative values. The survey items that load positively involve market discipline or policing (teacher accountability, police expansion), and the items that load negatively strengthen regulation and transparency (rent stabilization, police-performance reporting). The loadings of survey items on PC2 suggests that it captures pro-market/pro-policing attitudes that are orthogonal to overall support for the expansion of local government.

Figure 5: Map of Respondents Along PC Scales

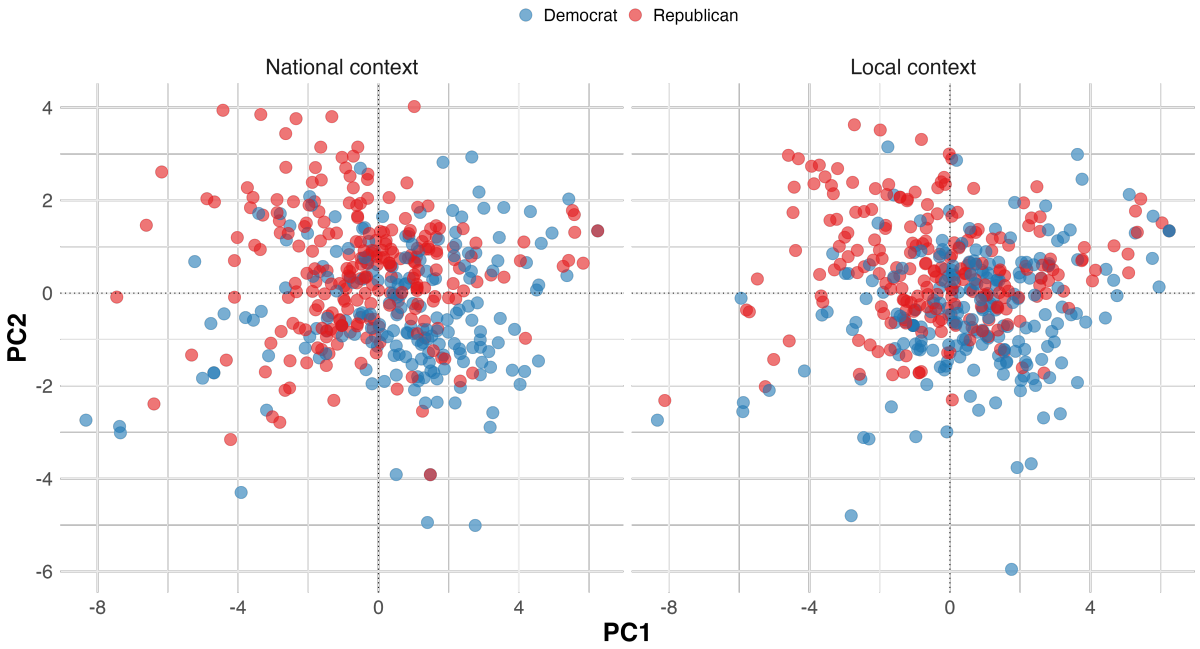


As shown, most respondents are clustered around the origin, indicating weak preferences.

Figure 5 shows every respondent mapped onto both components. As shown, most respondents are clustered near the origin, suggesting that a significant portion of them do not hold strong opinions on either expanded local government or favor a pro-market/pro-police stance. Additionally, Figure 5 shows that preferences on these two components are continuous. PC1 is spread wider than PC2 due to the nature of their eigenvalues, but respondents

typically fall within four standard-deviations for either axis.

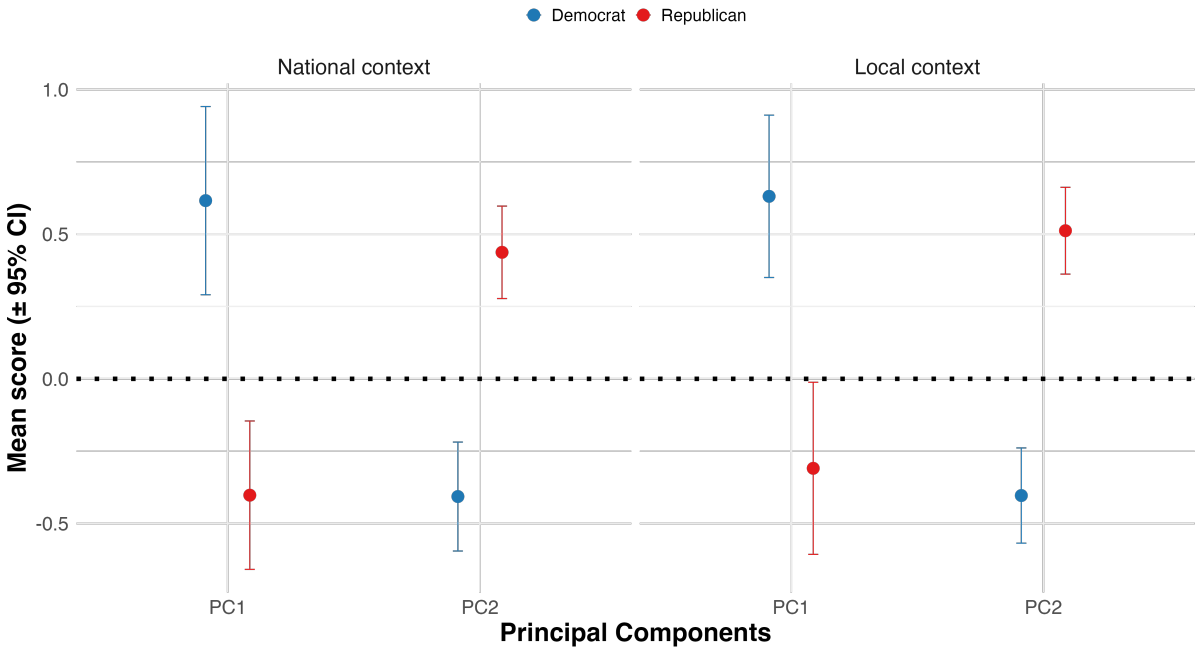
Figure 5a: Respondents Mapped by Partisanship and Treatment Condition



Respondents are clustered around the origin for both treatment groups. The theory suggests that there would be a clear division between Republicans and Democrats in the National condition and no division in the Local Condition. As shown, that is not the case.

Figure 5a displays all respondents split by party placed into panels by their treatment group. In both the *National* and *Local* groups, Democrats and Republicans overlap along PC1 and PC2. At the individual level among respondents, within-party variance dwarfs the between-party shift, so Democrats and Republicans comingle around the origin. However, to fully illustrate the difference between Democrats and Republicans, Figure 4 displays the results from averaging component scores for respondents in both parties and in both treatment groups. It is apparent that this evidence is contrary to what **H2** would have predicted, which is that the partisan gap would have been reduced under a local context. Figure 6 still displays an interesting gap between Democrats and Republicans, with Democrats displaying more support for expanded local government items and Republicans showing more support for pro-market/pro-policing survey items.

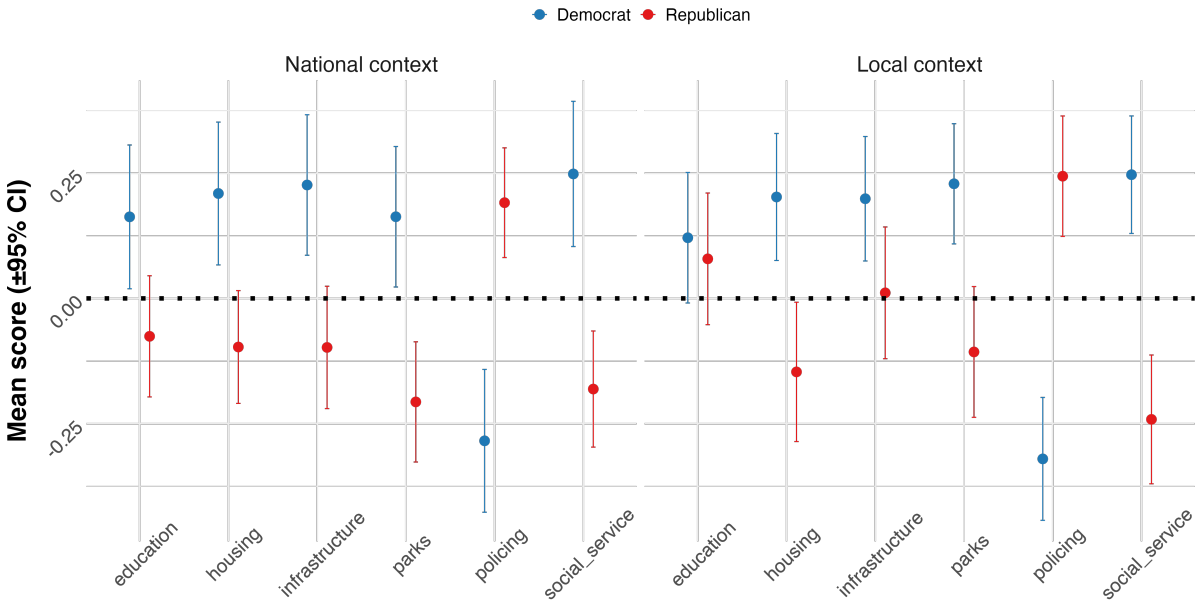
Figure 6: Preferences by Party and Treatment Group



Mean was calculated by the scores of each individual respondent. Positive values indicate support and negative values indicate opposition. Responses to local policies were recoded so that support is positive. There is no significant difference between treatment groups.

Policy Areas

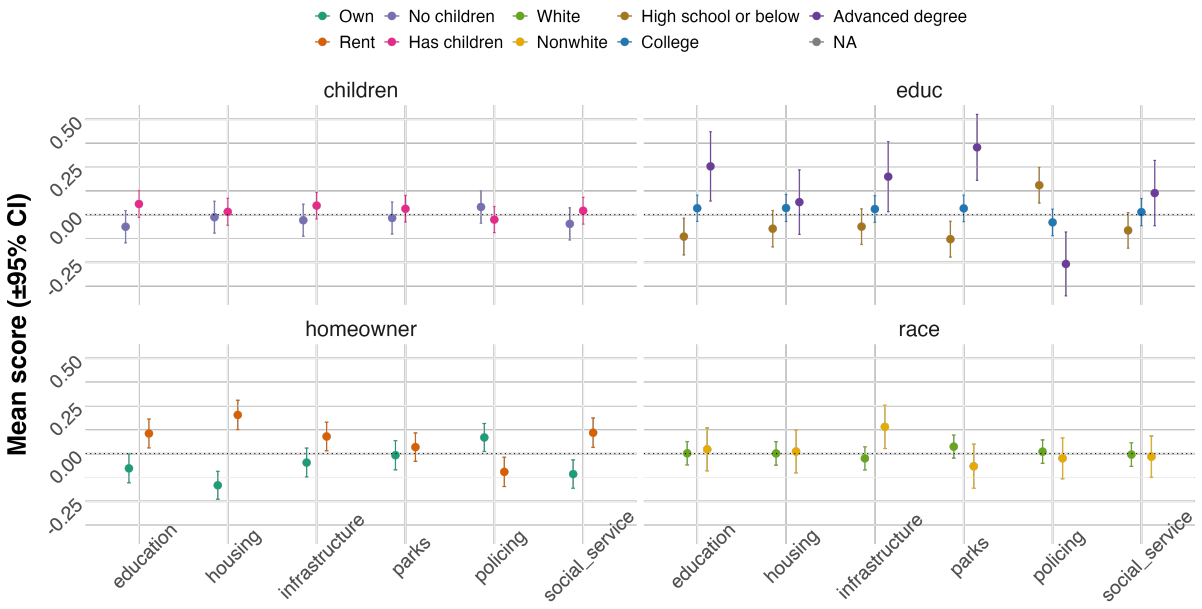
Figure 7: Preferences by Party and Issue Area



Positive values indicate support. Democrats consistently support local policies while Republicans are either indifferent or in opposition. Dotted line indicates the average survey respondent.

To further investigate any partisan gap across specific policy, I conducted another PCA to calculate scores for each policy item (housing, education, policing, social services, infrastructure, and parks). Figure 5 shows mean attitudes towards different policies from both parties across treatment groups. On average, Democrats reliably support expanding local government services across almost all policy domains except for policing. Republicans consistently support policing and oppose social services more than the average respondent and are not more likely to support other policies. Substantively, these differences are large enough to be systematic but not so large as to leave plenty of room for individual Democrats and Republicans to overlap.

Figure 8: Prefernces by Background and Issue Area



Dotted line indicates the average survey respondent. The 'children' variable represents parenthood status. Parenthood and race groups do not affect policy preferences compared to the average respondent.

Shifting attention to investigating if self-interest can explain local policy preference, Figure 8 looks at how the six policy issues shift against four demographic variables: homeownership, parental status, race, and education levels. Figure 8 shows several intuitive relationships such as renters being more supportive of expanded housing policy and homeowners being in opposition. There is also a clear relationship that exists between preference and education level. Graduate-degree holders are generally more supportive of most policies except for policing, a relationship which is most likely related to respondent partisanship as shown in Figure 7. Against my expectations, having children does not affect respondent preferences towards any policy. Overall, it appears that education level and homeownership status largely influence policy issues when examining non-partisan identities.

Finally, I choose to identify whether an individual respondent's partisanship or other background variable shapes attitudes towards each set of local policies. To estimate the

effects of the identity variables, I rely on a two-step post-Lasso regression with the first step being defined as:

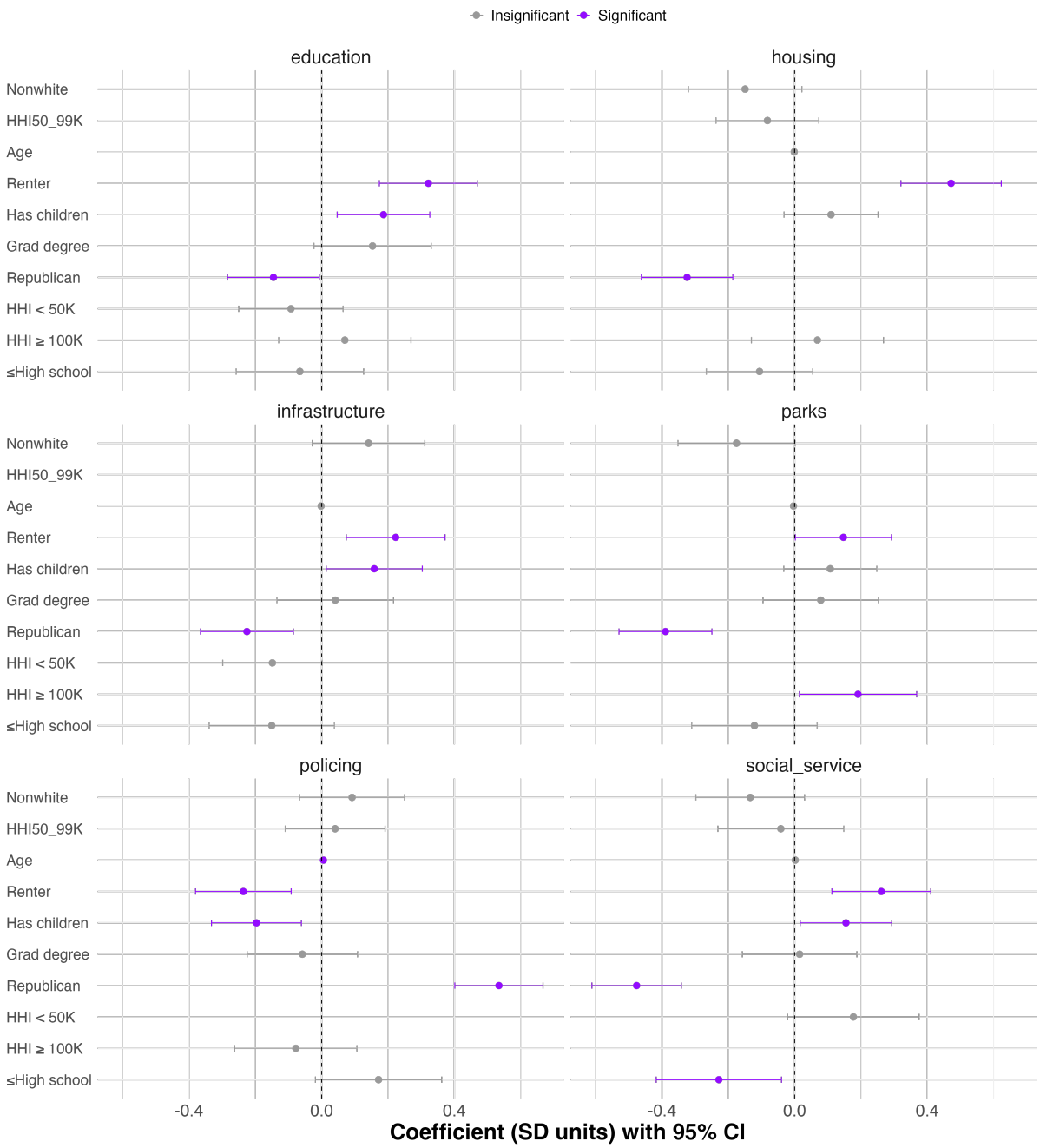
$$\hat{\beta}_d^{LASSO} = \arg\min_{\beta} \{ \frac{1}{2n} \sum_{i=1}^{n} (Y_{id} - X_i^T \beta)^2 + \lambda \sum_{j=1}^{p} |\beta_j| \},$$

where Y_{id} is the standardized principal component score for issue d and X_i contains identity variables such as party, homeownership, parental status, race, education, age, and income. Using ten-fold cross-validation, I'm able to select the penalty term λ to shrink any irrelevant coefficients, which leaves me with a set of predictors $\hat{S}_d$. For the second step, I fit an OLS model using the set of predictors and relying on robust standard errors:

$$Y_{id} = \alpha_d + X_{i,\hat{S}_d}^T \beta_{d,\hat{S}_d} + \epsilon_{id}$$

I primarily use this method to reduce insignificant predictors and to penalize any variables that are multicollinear since the provided identity variables are likely to be all related in some way. I chose this method over more elaborate methods since it seems like the actual treatment that respondents were given was ineffective, so this method suffices for this descriptive analysis. I address heteroskedasticity and overfitting by estimating robust standard errors and using cross-validation. The results of the post-Lasso method are shown in Figure 9 below.

Figure 9: Significant Predictors of Local Policy Preference



Purple coefficients and CIs are statistically significant. Values without point estimates or CIs were dropped in the LASSO process and can be considered as not predictive of support for the local policy area. Negative coefficients indicate opposition.

Figure 9 shows that at least two variables dominate each local policy preference. First,

homeownership status is the largest driver in housing and education preference, with renters being more likely to support these issues relative to homeowners. Second, partisanship is consistently a statistically significant predictor or local policies across the board. Confirming earlier results, Republicans are less likely to support many local policies compared to other partisans except for policing, where Republicans are the most likely to support out of any other background group. Other demographic groups such as parenthood rarely exceed a substantively large amount once party and homeownership are included. These post-Lasso results reveal a clear partisan cleavage across all six local policy areas that were in the survey.

Discussion

This purpose of this project was to understand whether citizens evaluate local policy through the same partisan lends that dominates local politics or whether a shift to a local context encourages individuals to be self-interested and consider their nonpartisan backgrounds. **H1** suggests that a national context would influence survey respondents to be partisans, which was still observed to be true. However, **H2** also suggested that a shift in attention to a local context would influence nonpartisan behavior, which the results show no evidence of. Theoretically, I fail to accept these hypotheses and can only show that there is a partisan element to the formation of local policy preferences. These findings refine our understanding of how partisan identity interacts with self-interest, and that political behavior could be "intoxicated" with partisanship.

The principal component analysis provides one important insight to the formation of local policy preferences. Local government policies are typically viewed among two distinct dimensions. The first dimensions suggest a preference for the expansion of local services and the second dimension shows a preference for market solutions and policing. Alternatively, these dimensions mirror relationships we observe at the national level, where there is a preference towards government expansion or a preference towards law-and-order and a government that is more hands off. These dimensions reflect key ideologies that have dominated

American politics for centuries, and they explain the foundation behind how Americans can form their policy preferences. Individuals can use the same ideologies that they use to evaluate national policies at the local level. So, it's still possible that individuals could not be completely partisan and could have underlying ideologies that dictate their preferences.

In other words, as Hopkins (2018) states, both the Democratic and Republican party are "... perceived to offer the same choices throughout the country." At the national level, Democrats have typically championed social investment, redistributive policies, and public provision. On the other hand, Republicans have typically championed "small-government" policies and a "law-and-order" mindset. Many Democrats are renters, work in the public-sector, and rely on social services while living in dense metropolitan areas where collective goods are highly valued. It is intuitive that Democrats would support the expansion of local governments to enable them to reap greater benefits from the services offered by municipalities. There are many Republicans that live outside of dense, urban areas, who wouldn't see the same value in expanded local governments the same way that urban Democrats would. Instead, they value a government that lets the market make decisions, and that values its police officers for their services. Republicans also associate more with the "back-the-blue" movement, so their consistent support for the police is unsurprising.

Finding that partisanship remains a dominant predictor of local policy attitudes even when accounting for background characteristics such as homeownership, education, income, race, age, and parental status is the most important finding in this project. I believe this finding is the result of two potential factors. First, partisanship is a strong identity, and it helps individuals make sense of the political world. Many Americans lack information about their local governments because they lack access or interest. So, when individuals are asked to provide opinions on local policies, they rely on partisanship for the sake of cognitive efficiency to provide answers, even when they don't have any underlying positions. The second factor is that local politics could already be tainted with partisanship. Candidates for local offices could already be using national talking points about immigration, policing,

environmental regulation in their campaigns. In other words, local elites could be anchoring local policies in a partisan framing to help themselves gain support. Like the first factor, individuals are largely uninformed about their local governments and local elites may try to use a cognitively familiar framework to help themselves gather support and win their local elections. The use of partisan framing in local politics could lead individuals to start to develop partisan preferences, meaning that a local context would be ineffective.

There are also several limitations that this project and its findings face. First, the failure of the experimental prime to influence policy preferences needs to be carefully interpreted. It is clear that there was an emotional difference in responses between both primes. Those in the National group expressed more negative emotions, and those in the Local group expressed positivity. The text analysis shows that people were viewed the national elections as very contentious and unnerving, while many people thought their local elections were pleasant. Despite the difference in emotional response, there was no difference between both treatment groups in their use of partisan language or in their policy preferences. One cause of these findings could be that the treatment was weak. A single, brief reflection exercise may have been insufficient to change respondents' focus to local politics, especially if individuals are deeply lodged into partisan and national contexts over years of media consumption and social identification. This is plausible since there was also no difference in mentions of Trump between either group, signifying that the prompt just primed individuals to think of national elections in general. These findings could also be interpreted as a sign that nationalization is strong, and that Americans truly do process information, no matter the context, in a national partisan framework. More work needs to be done on the underlying psychological mechanism before any strong conclusion could be made on the response to the prompts.

Another limitation that could drastically affect the results is that there was no analysis on the differences in respondents from urban and rural areas. The differences observed between Democrats and Republicans could be driven by location since Democrats occupy dense urban areas and Republicans are in rural areas. Not only would an urban/rural divide

drive specific policy preferences, but it may also influence how individuals perceive their local governments entirely. Respondents in rural areas mostly deal with county officials and have access to significantly less municipal services than an individual in an urban city. Location and availability of public services could ultimately be the primary factor of preferences towards the expansion of local services.

Finally, individuals could experience difficulties in attributing certain policies to their local governments. There are three levels of government that all pass policies on the same area such as education. It can be difficult for individuals to know which level of government is responsible for the policies that they are experiencing and obtaining that information would be costly. Rather than going through the work of gathering information, individuals can continue to rely on the shortcuts readily available to them to make quick judgements on certain policies, which could result in them misattributing policies to certain governments. The responsibilities of certain policies by levels of government are further complicated by the variation across different states. Future work should be aware of the complicated structure of government and that the limited information that survey respondents have available to them could affect how they perceive local policies.

Despite the limitations, this project still possesses some notable strengths. The findings from the PCA on all local policy issues and across all issue areas confirm each other and show that there are different dimensions of preferences across local policies. The findings from the post-Lasso also confirm the results from the PCA, showing that my results are robust. Both methods also show that there are other factors, along with partisanship that influence local policy preferences, which continues to confirm the findings found by research on homeownership.

Conclusion

Studies on political behavior have consistently pointed towards partisanship being one of the primary factors that influences vote choice in the United States. Many studies have

shown that partisanship is an important social identity that enables individuals to understand their political environment and provides a shortcut to making quicker, and cognitively less demanding, political decisions. However, other researchers have argued that previous observations on partisanship suffer from reverse causation. Individuals may have one or two policy issues that they have preferences on, which ultimately explain their partisan identity. In the end, people may just care about policy agreement over partisanship. These two arguments ultimately display that there is more to learn about whether individuals are inherently partisan or if they have policy preferences that explain their behavior.

The tension from the research on partisanship is also reflected in the local political behavior field. Nationalization suggests that local political behavior mirrors national behavior since it also has partisan elements. However, current research does not have enough evidence to show that there are enough similarities between national politics and local politics to conclude that there could be a relationship between policy preferences at both levels. This gap in the literature can ultimately be explained by whether individuals are partisan at the local level or if they do have policy preferences that define their behavior. If they are partisan, then studies on nationalization are strengthened. However, the differences in local governments makes it plausible for individuals to behave as self-interested actors, relying on their other background identities and preferences to make political decisions in local politics. If individuals are self-interested, then researchers would need to reconsider previous findings on local political behavior and start accounting for locality specific differences.

There are many factors that could highlight whether individuals are partisans or self-interested in local politics. One factor is that individuals could perceive local policies differently conditional on the context they view policies in. In this paper, I argued that context affects how individuals perceive local policies. In a national context, where individuals primarily focus on national actors, a nationalized mindset emerges, leading individuals to perceive policies through a partisan lens. Conversely, in a local context where local elites and communities are the main actors, individuals will tend to prioritize self-interested pref-

erences.

Using an original survey design, I tested whether there was a relationship between context and preferences, and whether local policy preferences mapped onto dimensions that correlated with partisanship or other background identities. Despite the experiment being ineffective, I find that respondents tend to view local policies on partisan dimensions, even when accounting for their background identities such as their homeownership status and parenthood status. These results are also robust across different local policy areas.

This project contributes to the tension in the literature on nationalization by providing additional evidence of partisan behavior in local politics. Even though local governments are focused on providing services in a nonpartisan fashion, individuals could ultimately still view the actions in a partisan lens. The same ideologies that influence national preferences can still be used to evaluate local policies, making it easier for individuals to simplify local politics and form preferences.

This project also contributes to the tension in the literature on policy preference formation by providing evidence of the strength of partisan identity in preferences. While other background identities were predictors of policy preference, partisanship consistently proved to be the main factor in preferences across multiple policy areas. To clarify, I'm not suggesting that other identities don't matter at all, as the evidence from this project and other studies show that people will act in their own interest to protect their property values. However, people are uninformed about local politics, which could lead to them behaving as partisans for matters that aren't particularly significant for their lives. An important note is that it is unlikely that these other background identities will sort into different parties. This allows for individuals to still have multiple, interacting identities that will dictate policy preference.

The broad implication of this study is that there can be partisan behavior in local politics, even when partisanship is supposedly absent from local institutions. In nonpartisan elections, local elites can still find it effective to signal their partisan allegiance to garner support. Even

in cities that have a homogenous partisan population, elites can still signal their ideology to show their preferences towards the expansion of local services or their support towards the police. This would be favorable to both local candidates and voters because there is a readily available compass that would allow many individuals to navigate complex local issues, which would encourage greater participation in local elections. But partisanship could be a double-edged sword, allowing for local officials to be punished for their partisan identity whenever attitudes shift towards policies at other levels of government. If local elites want to soften the effects of partisanship, they will need to anchor their constituents in community-specific issues to avoid misattribution. Overall, partisan behavior at the local level could result in a change in democratic accountability.

This project also serves as a template for future work on public opinion in local politics. Survey experiments could supply richer sources of local context through a variety of mediums, such as engaging videos on local politics, social media posts from local officials, and news stories from communities across the country. The scope of future work can also be drastically reduced to focus on area-specific issues, as individuals have different preferences in various parts of the country. Survey experiments or field work could have area-specific manipulations that would be more effective since it would be more familiar to subjects. This type of work could also be insightful in investigating any differences between urban and rural areas. The services provided in rural areas are drastically different than the services provided in dense, urban areas. Focusing on the variance in service provision could also show differences in how individuals perceive local policies. Finally, place-specific panel surveys could reveal whether preferences on local policies are stable, which would suggest that individuals do have stable ideologies for local politics. Panel studies would also provide insight onto how stable local governments are in the policies they focus on. How long do local governments focus on specific issues, what steps do they take to address these issues, and how do preferences shift whenever the government makes progress (if any)? There are many research ideas on public opinion in local politics that are ripe to be acted on. As these studies take place, we will be

able to gain a greater understanding on how Americans form their policy preferences and address the current tensions in the literature.

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